3

MILLION

VACANT POSTS ACROSS ALL STATES, AS PER SEVERAL UNOFFICIAL ESTIMATES

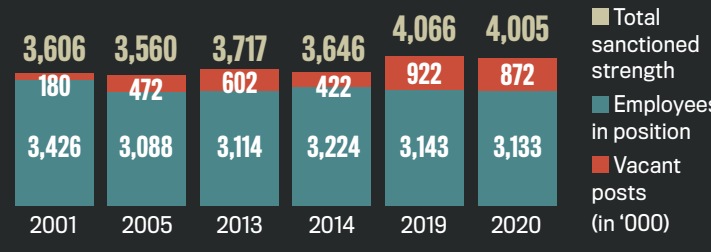
cent. That was the second wave. The depression entrenched all around us then has not entirely lifted.

There are two circles here, one contained entirely within the other. The idea of a "secure government job"—clearly making a comeback—is primarily an index of the surrounding gloom, the larger circle of distress. Take agriculture: what you hear is, again, voices of anger and distress. Farming accounts for only 14 per cent of our economy but absorbs 42 per cent of the workforce. However, that absorption capacity is clearly shrinking, as are the incomes. It's precisely from the land-holding middle castes that India saw a spate of protests demanding OBC reservations in recent times—the Jats, the Patels, the Marathas—and copycat protests from displaced beneficiaries like the Gujjars. Reservations point in only one direction: government jobs.

The question is, can the public sector cater to this new hunger? Caught in the throes of change in a transitional economy, it's hardly immune to the cycles of low growth. The CMIE estimates India had 53 million unemployed as of December 2021. Yet, the existing posts cannot absorb even 10 per cent of India's unemployed. If the Centre and states fill up all existing vacancies, only around 4

THE CENTRAL WORKFORCE

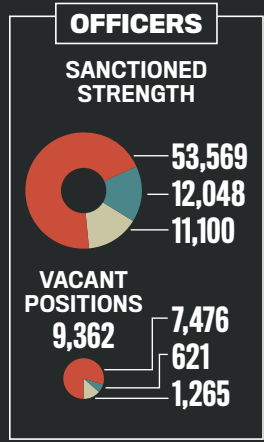
While the number of sanctioned positions has increased in the past two decades, the vacant posts have multiplied nearly eight times

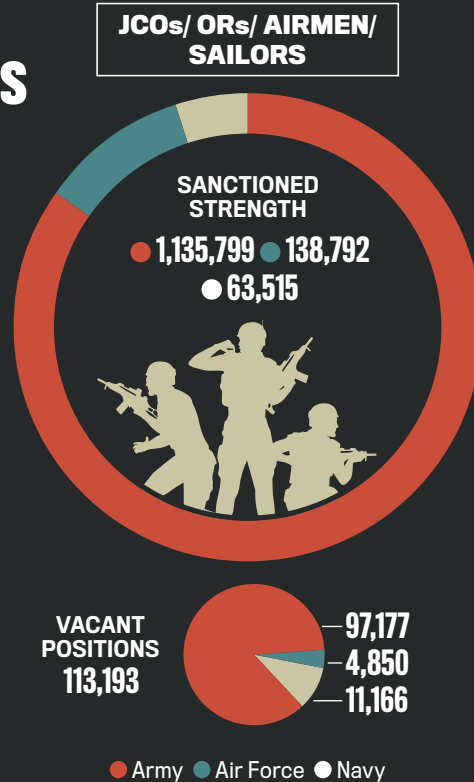


Source: Pay Research Unit, Department of Expenditure, Ministry of Finance

VACANCIES IN ARMED FORCES

122,555 or 14 per cent of the total vacancies in central government are in armed forces

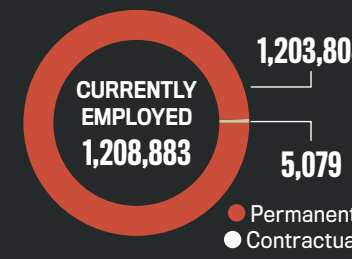


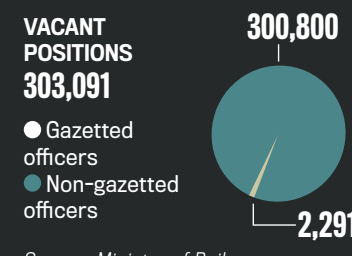


Source: Ministry of Defence, Lok Sabha, December 13, 2021

VACANCIES IN RAILWAYS

303,091 or 35 per cent of the total central government jobs are in railways





Source: Ministry of Railways, February 4, Lok Sabha

Graphics by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY